

IEEE Computer Society AI Caravan

Bridging the knowledge gap from Region 8 to the global stage

by Islam Tharwat Abdel Halim 

Introduction: A new paradigm for artificial intelligence

The rapid growth of artificial intelligence (AI) has created a gap between those who can develop AI solutions and those who only use technology. This gap is more than a challenge of access; it can prevent communities and regions from benefiting from the opportunities created by AI. In 2025, the IEEE Computer Society (CS) Member and Geographic Activities Board launched the IEEE CS AI Caravan to help bridge this gap. More than a series of events, the AI Caravan combines the CS' global mission with a practical, community-focused approach. Built around the theme "The Right to Knowledge and Practical Application in AI—Leaving No One Behind," the initiative brings AI knowledge and hands-on experience directly to diverse communities. We believe that AI knowledge is the "electricity" of the 21st century, a vital resource that should be accessible to everyone to support innovation and development.

The initiative is closely aligned with the United Nations (UN) 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. By expanding access to AI education, the Caravan supports human development and social progress. Its mission is to empower key sectors, including healthcare, education, agriculture, energy, digital transformation, and culture, with the knowledge needed to improve services and support sustainable growth. In doing so, the Caravan contributes to the UN goals of inclusive, high-quality education and lifelong learning opportunities for all. The Caravan is built around three primary pillars:

- **Pillar 1: Empowering Professionals and Promoting Access to Knowledge:** This pillar is dedicated to train-

ing and supporting professionals across key sectors through comprehensive programs that translate cutting-edge research into practical, implementation-ready solutions. It focuses on creating actionable strategies for AI integration that align with local and sector-specific challenges.

- **Pillar 2: Educating School Students and Fostering Entrepreneurship:** Recognizing that the innovators of tomorrow are in today's classrooms, this pillar focuses on AI fundamentals and the cultivation of an entrepreneurial spirit. It aims to move school students from the role of technological observers to creators, preparing them to lead the next generation of AI-driven start-ups through mentorship and the Gen Z Junior Competition.
- **Pillar 3: AI Summit:** The Caravan culminated in a leading international summit focused on applied and multidisciplinary AI research and technologies, featuring globally renowned AI leaders who showcased cutting-edge advancements and discussing the future of AI. The event provided a platform for knowledge exchange, networking, and fostering collaboration across sectors to accelerate the adoption of AI.

Visionary leadership: The architects of the Caravan

The success of the AI Caravan is anchored in a robust global leadership structure that spans the highest levels of IEEE. This initiative was conceptualized and executed under the strategic guidance of key figures who recognize that the CS' future depends on its ability to engage with emerging tech hubs. The 2026 IEEE President Mary Ellen Randall and IEEE President-Elect Candidate David Koehler have provided the high-level advocacy necessary to ensure the Caravan is recognized as a top-tier priority for the global engineering community. The institutional

continuity of the Caravan is guaranteed by a distinguished lineage of CS leaders (Fig. 1):

- Hironori Washizaki (2025 President)
- Grace A. Lewis (2026 President)
- Joaquim Jorge (2027 President)
- Andrew Seely (VP of Member and Geographic Activities)
- Eric Berkowitz (Director of Membership and Education)
- Yuhong Liu (2025 Geographic Activities Committee Chair)
- George J. Proeller (2025 Distinguished Visitor Program Chair)
- Islam Tharwat Abdel Halim [Region 8 Coordinator]

Regional synergy: Empowering R8

The AI Caravan chose IEEE R8, encompassing Europe, the Middle East, and Africa, as its inaugural staging ground. This choice was deliberate as R8 represents one of the most dynamic and rapidly growing segments of the global tech landscape. Specifically, the initiative focused on the synergy between North Africa and East Africa, drawing significant organizational support from the IEEE Egypt, Tunisia, and Kenya Sections. The “boots on the ground” were local volunteers who transformed the high-level strategy into tangible events. In North Africa, CS volunteers played pivotal roles in navigating the complex academic and industrial landscapes of Egypt and Tunisia. Their work was instrumental in securing venues and ensuring that the caravan was tailored to the specific needs of local professionals. In East Africa, the involvement of the IEEE CS Student Branch Chapter at Dedan Kimathi University of Technology (DeKUT) in Kenya expanded the Caravan’s reach through the TechX series (Fig. 2). Led by a dedicated team of student innovators, the Nyeri stop brought together over 200 tech enthusiasts for a two-day experience that blended learning, collaboration, and creativity. These volunteers acted as the vital link between the global IEEE structure and local communities, proving that the CS is not a distant entity but a localized force for good.

A coalition of excellence: Academic and industrial partners

The AI Caravan does not operate in a vacuum; it thrives within a dense ecosystem of partners who provide the intellectual and financial capi-

tal necessary for its success. This coalition represents a blend of globally recognized research institutions and local leaders in technology and education, all united by the goal of democratizing AI knowledge.

Academic, research, and educational partners

The academic partners provided the foundational research and the venues that made the workshops possible. DeKUT in Kenya, for instance, has established itself as a hub for East African smart tech transformation, while Egypt University of Informatics (EUI)’s presence in “Knowledge City” within Egypt’s New Administrative Capital provided a glimpse into the future of digital infrastructure.

- *University of Louisville (USA)*: Contributed research-backed insights for deep learning and AI in education through the University of Louisville’s Digital Transformation Center.



FIG1 Hironori Washizaki, 2025 CS president, and Islam Tharwat Abdel Halim, CS Region 8 coordinator, at the IEEE CS Global Chapter Summit in Tokyo, Japan, promoting the vision and global expansion of the IEEE CS AI Caravan initiative.



FIG2 Islam Tharwat Abdel Halim, CS R8 coordinator, with the participants of IEEE CS TechX Nyeri 2025 in Nyeri, Kenya, highlighting the collaborative efforts that supported the AI Caravan’s outreach and impact across East Africa.

- *University of Greater Manchester (United Kingdom)*: Contributed to the pilot project phase, providing exceptional technical support through the Centre of Intelligence of Things (CIoTh).
- *Coventry University (U.K./Cairo Branch)*: Hosted the kick-off meeting at The Knowledge Hub (TKH), focusing on industry-relevant AI skills.
- *The American University in Cairo (AUC)*: A primary host for foundational workshops and the Regional Summit through the School of Continuing Education.
- *Nile University*: A cornerstone partner that hosted several competitive programming and AI sessions and provided technical and research support for the pilot projects through the School of Information Technology and Computer Science; the Graduate School of Management of Technology (MoT) the Center for Informatics Science (CIS); and the Innovation, Entrepreneurship and Competitiveness Center (IECC).
- *German University in Cairo (GUC)*: Focused on demystifying technical pillars for professionals.
- *Egypt University of Informatics (EUI)*: The host of the concluding ceremony and a leader in digital transformation.
- *Arab Academy for Science, Technology and Maritime Transport (AASTMT)*: Integrated AI training into logistics and maritime contexts.
- *El Sewedy University of Technology (SUT)*: Promoted industry-oriented AI education by connecting students with practical applications of AI and supporting hands-on learning experiences aligned with workforce needs.
- *Badr University in Cairo (BUC)*: played a vital role as a hub for healthcare research and innovation by supporting multidisciplinary projects that address real-world healthcare challenges.
- *The National Academy of Information Technology for Persons with Disabilities (NAID)*: Provided professional training support and capacity-building opportunities, helping participants enhance their practical skills in AI and related digital technologies.
- *North American Private University*: Hosting and leading the AI Caravan activities in Tunisia through the International Institute of Technology (IIT) (Fig. 3).
- *University of Sfax (Tunisia)*: Strengthened the regional dimension of the AI Caravan by supporting cross-border collaboration, knowledge exchange, and AI awareness activities within the North African academic community.
- *Dedan Kimathi University of Technology (DeKUT), Kenya*: Spearheaded the TechX series in Nyeri.
- *Additional partners*: Including ECU, ACU, and EN CARTHAGE.

Industrial, media, and community engagement

The success of the IEEE CS AI Caravan was further strengthened through the support of several strategic partners from industry, government, and media sectors. TENET Information Technology served as the Gold Sponsor, providing major financial support for the Regional Summit and contributing significantly to the initiative's logistical requirements. Fortinet joined as a Silver Sponsor

and played a leading role in cybersecurity education by supporting specialized training activities and sponsoring student activities. Digital Arrow contributed as an Industrial Partner, offering technical solutions, as well as media production support that enhanced the quality and reach of the Caravan's activities. The Ministry of Finance of Egypt provided strategic patronage, supporting the implementation of pilot projects and reinforcing the initiative's alignment with national digital transformation objectives. In addition, Watan Raqami and Extra News served as Media Partners, delivering extensive coverage of the AI Caravan's journey and achievements through national television broadcasts and digital news platforms, thereby amplifying its impact and visibility across the region.

The roadmap: Twenty-five stops on the journey to intelligence

The operational scale of the 2025 AI Caravan was immense, featuring 15 in-person workshops and 10 specialized online sessions, reaching more than 600 participants across multiple nations. The roadmap was designed as a structured learning journey, starting with foundational theory and moving toward specialized, real-world application. The journey included the following key stops:

- *TKH*: The 27 February launch focusing on collaboration as a catalyst.
- *FDC and NAID*: Sessions on 29 April and 8 May exploring national digital infrastructure.
- *AUC and GUC*: Mid-May workshops that demystified the AI landscape.
- *Nile University*: Several sessions, including the management of technology and practical application perspectives.
- *SUT and AASTMT*: July stops focusing on industrial and maritime AI applications.
- *Knowledge City (EUI)*: The grand finale on 31 July, celebrating the completion of the Egypt leg (Fig. 4).

Technical depth was a hallmark of these sessions. Rather than generic overviews, the Caravan delivered specialized content.

Case study: Transforming the Egyptian Tax Authority

The most significant validation of Pillar 1 (Empowering Professionals) occurred within the Egyptian public sector. This case study illustrates how the AI Caravan moved beyond the classroom to catalyze institutional change. Based on the directives of His Excellency the Minister of Finance (MOF), Mr. Ahmed Kouchouk, and following the MOF and Egyptian Tax Authority (ETA)'s participation in the Caravan workshops between April and July 2025, Ms. Rasha Abdel Aal, the head of the ETA, announced the formation of a dedicated AI task force (Fig. 5). Abdel Aal emphasized that keeping pace with global technological shifts is no longer optional; it is an "urgent necessity" for boosting institutional performance and improving service quality for taxpayers. The task force was established to integrate AI into Egypt's tax system, specifically



FIG3 The participants of the 2025 IEEE CS AfroTech Intelligence Congress hosted by IIT in Sousse, Tunisia, highlighting the collaborative efforts that supported the AI Caravan's outreach and impact across North Africa.



FIG4 Professional participants receiving certificates during the closing ceremony of the AI Caravan capacity-building program at Knowledge City New Capital, Egypt, marking the successful completion of Pillar 1: Empowering Professionals and Promoting Access to Knowledge.



FIG5 A pilot project team from the ETA presenting TAXGPT and AI-based tax revenue forecasting solutions at the IEEE AI Caravan Regional Summit hosted by the American University in Cairo, Egypt. The projects exemplify the AI Caravan's mission of transforming AI knowledge into practical applications with societal and institutional impacts.

focusing on “intelligent analytics” and “data-driven decision-making.” This was not a purely theoretical exercise. During the Caravan sessions, ETA representatives proposed several pilot projects designed to address operational challenges, such as fraud detection and the modernization of tax administration. These proposals were approved for implementation, with a focus on maintaining international standards for data security and confidentiality. This real-world impact proves that the Caravan is effectively “electrifying” the Global South by providing the technical blueprints for digital sovereignty.

Beyond the Egyptian Tax Authority, the AI Caravan also initiated several additional AI use cases and pilot projects in collaboration with both the Ministry of Finance (MOF) and the Ministry of Investment and Foreign Trade (MIFT). These initiatives explored the application of AI to enhance government operations, improve decision-making, and accelerate digital transformation across multiple public services. Their successful initiation was made possible through the continuous support and strategic vision of Mr. Ahmed Abdelrazek, the Permanent Undersecretary of the Ministry of Finance; and Ms. Yomna Elshbarawy, Head of Trade Remedies Sector, whose leadership played a key role in facilitating cross-sector collaboration and translating AI awareness into practical implementation.

Spotlight on Gen Z: The Junior Competition and future innovators

While Pillar 1 focused on today's professionals, Pillar 2 turned the spotlight on Gen Z. The Gen Z CS Junior Training Program was designed to foster an entrepreneurial mindset in school students. We believe that curiosity is the single most desirable trait in the industry, and the Caravan provided a platform for that curiosity to flourish. The program saw students tackle some of the world's most pressing challenges. By participating, these students moved from being “consumers” of AI to “creators” of solutions. A dedicated series of outreach workshops were

hosted at the American University in Cairo and Nile University, designed for school students (Fig. 6). These sessions introduced participants to the fundamentals of AI, focusing on core concepts in an accessible and interactive way. In addition to technical awareness, the workshops emphasized entrepreneurial thinking by guiding students on how to identify real-world problems, think creatively, and develop innovative solutions. Participants were also introduced to the basics of building an AI-driven startup, including how to structure a simple business model, define value propositions, and connect AI capabilities to market needs. The overall objective was to foster both foundational AI literacy and an entrepreneurial mindset among early-stage learners, enabling them to envision how AI can be transformed into viable business opportunities.

Another highlight of the IEEE CS AI Caravan was the CS Junior Competition, which brought together more than 25 school student teams from across Egypt to showcase innovative AI-driven solutions. While most teams were graduates of the AI Caravan's Gen Z training program, the competition was also open to other students in line with the initiative's commitment to inclusivity and ensuring that no one is left behind. The competition began with a project exhibition at AUC, followed by final presentations at Nile University before a distinguished jury comprising David Koehler, Yuhong Liu, George J. Proeller, Islam Tharwat Abdel Halim, Kostas Karpouzis, and Moussa Al-Akhras (Fig. 7). The creativity and technical excellence demonstrated by the participants highlighted the immense potential of the next generation of AI innovators and entrepreneurs. The following five teams were recognized for their outstanding performance and impact.

The Junior Hall of Fame

- **Egyptian Fraud Investigator Team:** An AI system built to detect financial irregularities, inspired by the ETA's modernization drive.
- **ICOTeam:** A project focused on intelligent agents for community communication and social cohesion.
- **Edu Futurit Team:** An AI-driven personalized learning platform designed to make STEM subjects more accessible to fellow students.

- **PulmoDx AI:** A healthcare initiative using computer vision to assist in the early diagnosis of pulmonary diseases, showcasing AI's potential in life sciences.
- **AI Farming Health Shield:** An agricultural project using sensors and AI to monitor crop health, addressing the UN's goal of food security through sustainable technology.

The flagship: The 2025 Regional Summit in Cairo

The crowning achievement of the initiative was the three-day Regional Summit held from 11 to 13 December 2025 (Fig. 8). Hosted across the campuses of AUC and Nile University, the summit served as a global forum where the results of the Caravan were presented to the world. The event was held under the high-level patronage of the Egyptian Ministry of Finance and Prof. Dr. Mahmoud



FIG6 School students recognized at Nile University, Egypt, upon completing the AI Caravan's Gen Z program, celebrating the successful conclusion of Pillar 2 and the initiative's mission to inspire the next generation of AI innovators and entrepreneurs.



FIG7 A CS Junior Competition team presenting its project prototype to George J. Proeller, chair of the IEEE CS Distinguished Visitor Program, during the IEEE CS AI Caravan Regional Summit in Cairo, Egypt. The competition provided students with a valuable opportunity to present their ideas, engage with distinguished experts, and receive constructive feedback to further enhance their projects.

Mohieldin, the UN Special Envoy on Financing the 2030 Agenda. Dr. Mohieldin's presence underscored the Caravan's alignment with global sustainability goals. The summit was a masterclass in intergenerational knowledge transfer, where high school students from Pillar 2 interacted directly with the executive leaders of IEEE and government ministers. Keynote speakers discussed the ethical governance of technology and the "right to knowledge" as a human right. The summit was not just a celebration; it was a call to action. It provided a space for participants to network, share ideas, and build the "fabric of connectivity" that Andrew Seely often speaks about. The presence of international leaders like David Koehler, Yuhong Liu, George J. Proeller, Kostas Karpouzis, and Mousa Al-Akhras highlighted that the lessons learned in Cairo have global relevance.

Wisdom from the field: The Islam Tharwat perspective

During the Caravan's journey, Islam Tharwat, IEEE CS R8 coordinator, shared a set of reflections on career development and learning that became a central message in the initiative's student outreach. Drawing on more than 20 years of experience across government, industry, and academia, he emphasized a systems-thinking approach to understanding technology, education, and long-term professional growth.

AI as a new layer of abstraction

He highlighted that AI introduces a new layer of abstraction in computing, where humans can increasingly interact with machines in a natural, intuitive way. Just as assembly language and high-level programming languages once transformed how humans interact with computers, AI now extends this abstraction further. This shift is expected to significantly broaden access to programming and computing, enabling a much larger global community to become software creators and problem solvers.

Effort and outcomes

He also emphasized a principle often summarized as "students get what they get because they do what they do." This idea reinforces that consistent effort, practice, and engagement directly shape learning outcomes and professional achievement. Students were encouraged to continuously challenge themselves, invest effort deliberately, and strive for excellence in order to reach higher levels of performance.

Success, values, and integrity

A key message was that true success is not only about achieving goals and objectives but about achieving them while preserving core values and ethical principles. He stressed that maintaining integrity, responsibility, and ethical conduct throughout one's journey is the most difficult yet most important dimension of long-term success.

Preparing for a changing world

Finally, Islam highlighted that the world is undergoing rapid technological transformation, and future resources and opportunities may not always be abundant or predictable. In this context, students were encouraged to prepare themselves continuously, remain adaptable, and develop resilience for a future where technology and opportunities may be limited or unevenly distributed. The ability to adapt, learn, and reposition oneself was presented as a critical survival and success skill in the evolving digital era.

A global roster: Experts and volunteers

The AI Caravan was powered by a world-class roster of international speakers and a tireless team of local volunteers. These individuals embody the "volunteer spirit" that is the lifeblood of IEEE. Key international speakers were as follows:

- Adel S. Elmaghraby, director of research and innovation, Computer, Science and Engineering, University of Louisville



FIG8 Speakers and professional participants of the IEEE CS AI Caravan Regional Summit gathered during the first day of the event in Cairo, Egypt, reflecting the strong engagement and collaborative spirit fostered by the AI Caravan community.

- Celestine Iwendi, head of the ClOTh at the University of Greater Manchester
- Yiran Chen, professor of the Department of Electrical and Computer Engineering at Duke University
- Erol Gelenbe, professor in the Institute of Theoretical & Applied Informatics, Polish Academy of Sciences
- Kostas Karpouzis, associate professor, Panteion University of Social and Political Sciences, Greece
- Reyhan Aydogan, associate professor in AI and data engineering and computer science at Ozyegin University
- Seifedine Kadry, professor of data science at Noroff University College, Norway
- Tarek Khalil, founding president of Nile University
- Yasser Sakr, president of TKH Universities
- Ahmed M. Darwish, former minister of state for administration development
- Hoda Baraka, Advisor to the Minister of Communication and Information Technology for Technology Talents Development, Egypt
- Ahmed Hassan Yousef, president, Elsewedy University of Technology
- Abdel-Monem El-Sharkawy, chairman of the National Academy of Information Technology for Persons with Disabilities
- Ayman Nour Eldin, vice president and dean of pharmacy, Deraya University
- Ahmed Hazem El-Mahdy, dean of School of Information Technology and Computer Science, Nile University
- Mahmoud Allam, dean of the School of Continuing Education, AUC
- Samir Yussuf Mohamed Marzouk, dean of Quality and Productivity Institute, AASTMT
- Yasser Mohamed Ehab, deputy minister of finance for information technology, Egypt
- Ahmed N. Tantawy, founding director of the Applied Innovation Center, Ministry of Communication and Information Technology (MCIT), Egypt
- Khaled Ezzat Ahmed Negm, ICT minister advisor for digital governance, MCIT, Egypt
- Tamer A. Elbatt, professor at the CSE Department, The American University in Cairo (AUC)
- Walid Al-Atabany, associate dean for UG programs and director of Centre for Informatics, Nile University
- Ahmed H. Madian, professor and director for Electronics and Computer Engineering Program
- Mervat Abuelkheir, vice dean for student affairs, Faculty of Media Engineering and Technology, The German University in Cairo
- Mousa Al-Akhras, associate professor of computer information systems at the University of Jordan's King Abdullah II School of Information Technology
- Sherin M. Youssef, head of Computer College of Engineering, Arab Academy for Science and Technology
- Amal Elgammal, head of Software Engineering Department, Egypt University of Informatics (EUI),
- Hadeer Ehab Barakat, assistant professor of clinical pharmacy, British University in Egypt (BUE).
- Batoul Rida Haidar, assistant professor of computer science and AI, Coventry University.
- Doaa Salem, senior director, outreach and partnerships, School of Continuing Education (SCE), AUC.
- Samar M. Nour, assistant professor of computer engineering at Badr University in Cairo (BUC).
- Heba A. Shaban, professor of wireless communications, College of Engineering and Technology, AASTMT
- Ghada Khoriba, associate professor at the School of Information Technology and Computer Science, Nile University
- Mohamed Mostafa Eltoweel, head of educational departments at Arab Academy for Science, Technology and Maritime Transport, Smart Village, Egypt
- Maggie Mashaly, associate professor of AI and computer engineering, The German University in Cairo (GUC).
- Nada Sharaf, lecturer of informatics and computer science at the German International University, The German University in Cairo (GUC).
- Ahmed Abdel-Hafez, cybersecurity consultant, National Telecommunications Regulatory Authority (NTRA)
- Atef El Fekky, founder and CEO, Digital Arrow
- Ramy A. Fathy, chief of international cybersecurity affairs, NTRA



FIG9 The volunteer and organizing team of the IEEE CS AI Caravan Regional Summit on the final day of the event, showcasing the strong engagement of volunteers and representatives from across R8 who worked together to expand the initiative's reach and impact.

- Eslam Moussa, founder and CEO of TENET
- Karim Sheba, team lead, systems engineering, Fortinet
- Tarek Shabaka, founder and CEO, MCS
- Yehia Elgohary, Group CISO, efinance
- Mohamed AbdelFattah, regional business development manager IOT/OT, Fortinet
- Amr Ibrahim, data and AI cloud solution architect, Microsoft
- Mohamed Sami El-Tahawy, regional industry advisor | government-EMEA, Microsoft
- Aysha Alsafty, chief data scientist, Valeo
- Mohamed Amin, IEEE industry ambassador/private wireless sales lead, IEEE R8/Nokia
- Kareem Safwat, senior systems engineer, Fortinet
- Ahmed Saleh, director of IECC, Nile University
- Hesham El-Badawy, director, Central Administration for Research and Development, MCIT, Egypt
- Abdulazim Ghoniem, director, ICT Operation Projects and AI Governance Expert, MCIT, Egypt
- Heba Kaoud, assistant professor of innovation management and entrepreneurship, director of Intellectual Property and Technology Transfer Office, Nile University
- Alyaa A. Hamza, assistant professor at the Faculty of Engineering Technology, Elsewedy University of Technology-Polytechnic of Egypt
- Hady Habib, head of Energy and Renewable Energy Engineering Department at Egyptian Chinese University
- Martha Mahrous, deputy of communications and IT Committee in Egyptian Parliament
- Mohamed Salah, cybersecurity engineer, EG-CERT: Egyptian Computer Emergency Readiness Team
- Tamer Arafa, assistant professor of computer science and engineering, Nile University
- Noha Gamal, assistant professor of computer science, Nile University
- Aabdel Gawad El sayed, Assistant professor of computer engineering at Elsewedy University of Technology - SUT
- Emna Amri, chair of IEEE R8 Women in Engineering, Young Professionals chair of the IEEE France Section
- Harout Topjian, AI instructor, ZAKA | زكا
- Noha Abdelfattah Saad Salem, assistant director of grants and special programs, School of Continuing Education, AUC
- Yousef Yahya, community development coordinator, Nile University-NilePreneurs
- Asmaa Ahmed, deputy director of IECC, associate director of UIC and Impact.
- Hassan Othman, journalist and TV presenter, Watan Rakami
- Early Career Speakers: John Lorance William, Mohamed Fawzy, Omar Ashraf, Seif Eldin Ashraf, Ahmed Momen, Adham Elkomy, Omar Diab, Sarah Sherif Mohamed, Aliaa Khalid, Ahmed Amin, Hana Alaa Hussien, Mohamed Aboshama, Ibrahim El-Sadat, Youmna El Hossieny, Abdelrahman Wael, Mohamed Galal Eldin Elgemeie, Youssef Mohamed Elnagy, and Malak Walid.
- Volunteer Team: Mohamed Zouari, Mohamed Said Salah Hassan, Amr Nabih Riyad, Hassan Ahmed El Sayed, Mohannad Mohamed Abdelaziz, Esraa Magdy ElHossieny, Mohamed Kamal Said, John Mumo Nyerere, Lina Bouallegue, Taieb Djemal, Amal Romdhani, Mohamed Essam, Dareen Ahmed Sakr, Yousef Tamer Abbas, Mahmoud Hamad, Ahmed Mahmoud, Omar Ahmed Ibrahim, Alaa Taha El Maria, Omar Nour, Mohamed Bahgat, Mohamed Amir AbdelFatah, Arwa Ahmed, Mohamed Abdel Fata, Fatema Mohammad Mostafa, Ali Sherif, Reem Gedawy, Fady Maher, Muaid F Ben Fassi, Rue Kemboi, and Ann Muccheke (Fig. 9).

The horizon: Expansion and 2026 strategy

The 2025 AI Caravan activities in Egypt, Tunisia, and Kenya marked the first phase of a broader global vision. During the IEEE CS Global Chapter Summit 2026 in San Juan, Puerto Rico, CS leaders and regional coordinators discussed the AI Caravan's expansion roadmap for 2026 and 2027 (Fig. 10). The discussions included Andrew Seely, IEEE CS vice president for member and geographic activities; Eric Berkowitz, director of membership and education; Mohamed Rawidean, 2026 GAC chair; Islam Tharwat Abdel Halim, R8 coordinator and founder of the initiative; and regional coordinators from across the world. Building on its success in R8, the group explored opportunities to extend the AI Caravan to other regions, initially R9 (Latin America), with the support of Waldir Filho, R9 coordinator. The expansion vision received strong endorsement from CS leadership, recognizing the AI Caravan as an effective model for



FIG10 Participants of the IEEE CS Global Chapter Summit 2026 in San Juan, Puerto Rico, where CS leaders discussed and endorsed the expanded vision of the AI Caravan for 2026 and 2027.

advancing AI education, capacity building, entrepreneurship, and community engagement worldwide. The expansion plan includes the following:

- *The African reach*: Moving into Uganda, Rwanda, Algeria, and Libya to support the burgeoning tech ecosystems in East and North Africa.
- *The Middle East corridor*: Launching editions in Jordan, Saudi Arabia, and Kuwait to support national digital transformation agendas.
- *The European stops*: Establishing nodes in France, Turkey, Greece, and Germany to bridge the gap between academic research and industrial application.

Conclusion: Your place in the Caravan

The AI Caravan is more than a series of workshops; it is a movement that proves inclusive technology is a human right. By bringing the world's leading experts to the doorsteps of students in Cairo, Nyeri, and beyond, the CS is proving that the next great AI breakthrough could come from anywhere. As a student or young professional, the Caravan offers you a platform to stand on. It encourages you to move from being a "consumer" who merely uses AI tools to a "creator" who understands the architecture, the ethics, and the business logic behind them. The digital world does not care if

you are there, but if you show up with a plan, if you join the Society, and if you engage with its neighborhoods, the world of technology becomes your city. The Caravan is moving forward, and its destination is a future where no one is left behind in the age of intelligence. The platform is built, the "keys" are in your hands, and the road to Granada is open. The question is, Will you be on board?

About the author

Islam Tharwat Abdel Halim (ihalim@nu.edu.eg) earned his B.Sc. and M.Sc. degrees and his Ph.D. degree in computer and systems engineering from the Faculty of Engineering, Ain Shams University, Cairo, Egypt. His Ph.D. thesis was granted the best thesis award. He is currently an associate professor in the School of Information Technology and Computer Science, Nile University, Giza 12588, Egypt. His research interests include IoT; fog/edge computing; mobile and wireless networks, with emphasis on security and performance evaluation in vehicular communication; and 5G networks. He is currently appointed as the CS coordinator for R8 (Europe, Africa, and the Middle East), as well as the founder and current co-chair for the IEEE CS AI Caravan initiative. He is a Senior Member of IEEE.

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